Pencil Code Steering Committee (PCSC)

Terms of Reference

October 21, 2026, Revision: 1.64

1 Purpose

The PCSC is a standing committee whose purpose is to

- review and, when necessary, revise the Terms of Reference (ToR, this document),
- review and be responsible for the public information about the code on the Pencil Code websites,
- help initiating the continuation of annual Pencil Code User Meetings,
- invite Owners (=administrators in pencil-code.org) and decide about their privileges and responsibilities,
- assess and check that the list of Committers and Owners is up-to-date[1],
- deal with general concerns to the Pencil Code community (major code changes, conflicts, complaints),
- decide about major discussion items that need to be deferred to the next Pencil Code User Meeting,
- organize elections of the PCSC (every 3 years).

2 Organization of the PCSC

2.1 Chair

The PCSC elects its chair for the duration of 1–2 years. The chair continues until a new chair has been elected or re-elected, which will be the case prior to the first meeting after the chair's end of term. Rotation of the chair is encouraged. The chair selects a secretary for each meeting. Except for changes to the ToR, or if a veto is raised, the quorum of meetings is 3/5.

2.2 Members

The PCSC has five members. They are elected by the group of voters that comprises, all *Owners of the Pencil Code*[2] and those Committers who have participated in at least two Pencil Code User Meetings, and have

[1] `../committers/list.pdf`

[2] Owners of the Pencil Code (as of October 21, 2026):

	Name	UserID	Affiliation	Country
	Sven Bingert	bingert	GWDG (Göttingen)	Germany
∗	Philippe Bourdin	PABourdin	IWF (Graz)	Austria
∗	Axel Brandenburg	AxelBrandenburg	Nordita	Sweden
	Simon Candelaresi	iomsn	University of Glasgow	UK
∗	Piyali Chatterjee	mppiyali	Indian Inst Astrophys	India
	Boris Dintrans	bdintrans	IRAP Toulouse	France
	Wolfgang Dobler	wdobler	Potsdam/Berlin	Germany
	Frederick Gent	gent	Aalto Univ.	Finland
∗	Nils Haugen	nilshau	SINTEF (Trondheim)	Norway
	Tobias Heinemann	tobson	NBIA (Copenhagen)	Denmark
	Anders Johansen	ajohan	Lund Univ (Lund)	Sweden
	Maarit Korpi-Lagg	mjkorpi	Aalto Univ.	Finland
	Petri Käpylä	pkapyla	Freiburg	Germany
	Wladimir Lyra	wlyra	Univ New Mexico	USA
	Dhrubaditya Mitra	dhrubaditya	Nordita (Stockholm)	Sweden
∗	Matthias Rheinhardt	mrheinhardt	Aalto Univ (Espoo)	Finland
	Alberto Roper Pol		Geneva University	Switzerland
	Jennifer Schober	JenSchober	EPFL (Lausanne)	Switzerland
	Joern Warnecke	jwarne	MPS (Göttingen)	Germany
	Chao-Chin Yang	chaochinyang	Univ Nevada (Las Vegas)	USA
	Hongzhe Zhou	zhouhz1992	TDLI Institute, Shanghai	China

Asterisks denote PCSC members (since November 2020). Its current chair (from June 28, 2023) is Philippe Bourdin.

made at least 20 check-ins to the code within the last 5 years of the election[3]. Eligible members of the PCSC are Owners of the Pencil Code who have not declared their unavailability prior to the elections. The vote is anonymous and voting will be carried out electronically. Voting will be prepared by one of the Owners and approved by an observer. Both will be nominated by the chair of the PCSC.

If the outcome of the vote is ambiguous, a runoff round with the candidates who have equal vote counts is held. If the runoff round ends ambiguously again, the observer decides freely upon further measures to avoid runoff rounds in long sequence. These might include drawing lots or a willful decision of the observer.

3 Responsibilities of the PCSC

The PCSC reports to the Owners with a critical self-assessment. It is responsible for deciding what are major issues to be discussed. The PCSC is also responsible for monitoring the long-term integrity of the Pencil Code through the help of the auto-test. It also decides about Owners privileges. Owners, in turn, have the responsibility to maintain, improve, and disseminate the code. No individual Owner is allowed to delete it.

3.1 Meeting & Reporting

The PCSC convenes via telecon when issues emerge and at least once a year at least 1–2 months before the next Pencil Code User Meeting. The PCSC reports via email to the Owners. Upcoming meetings are announced to the Owners to solicit additional agenda items. The minutes will be available online.

3.2 Recurrent tasks

The PCSC reviews major code change requests or suggestions. (A major code change is one that cannot be reverted or avoided by switching modules, for example.) Owners may request that a particular item be discussed and thereby request that a PCSC meeting be held. A major code change may also be one that is sufficiently complex to foresee resulting major side effects. The PCSC is considering to give voting rights to individual Committers of the Pencil Code.

3.3 Review

The PCSC reviews its operations at each Pencil Code User Meeting. It is responsible for making changes to the ToR. All major changes must be approved by all Owners with a 2/3 majority. The PCSC also oversees the list of new Committers added by the Owners and makes sure the full names and affiliations of all Committers are known.

3.4 Complaints

Complaints[4] relevant to the Pencil Code community should be directed to all 5 members of the PCSC. When needed, the PCSC may then assemble an ad hoc committee to resolve the problem. The ad hoc committee, which decides by simple majority, should consist of five members from the Pencil Code community. If personal accusations are involved, both the accuser and the accused are allowed to appoint one member each who is not part of the conflict.

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[3] Use `git log --since 'today minus 5 years' --pretty=format:'%an' | sort| uniq -c | sort -rn` or select the time interval on github's graphics interface

[4] including violations of the `https://github.com/pencil-code/pencil-code/blob/master/license/CODE_OF_CONDUCT.md` (CoC). The CoC specifies the Community Leaders, i.e., the Owners, as responsible for its enforcement.